Week 3 Coding Challenge Summary

Nov 1, 2026 · @Robert

This week I got the ADHD budgeting app ready to build: I set up the project for AI-assisted coding, checked it against banking security rules, planned the build the Agile way, and grounded the design in research on ADHD.

The problem we are solving

About 1 in 14 adults has ADHD. Most budgeting apps need daily effort, long setups and close attention, so people with ADHD often quit within weeks. Money apps are not built for ADHD, and ADHD apps don't handle money. Our app does both: it shows what is **safe to spend** in one glance, and it welcomes people back after a break **without guilt**.

1. Setting up the project for AI-assisted coding

- Created the Week 3 project folder with a guide file (`CLAUDE.md`) that tells Claude Code, our AI coding helper, what the app is, which documents to read first and the rules to follow.
- Added **22 skills**. A skill is like a recipe card: Claude Code reads the matching card before it builds each part, so it follows our rules every time.
  - **10 skills we wrote ourselves**, such as `mvp-scope` (what goes in the first version), `adhd-ux-guidelines` (calm, kind screens), `safe-to-spend-math` (correct money math) and `banking-security` (locks, blur and auto-lock).
  - **12 expert skills**: 8 from Expo plus guides for Supabase, app speed, finding bugs and double-checking work.
- Chose the tools we plan to build with: Expo (iPhone and Android), Supabase (online backup) and Plaid (bank connections, practice banks only during the beta).

2. Research that shaped the design

- Read five ADHD design guides (2025 to 2026) and two research papers. Each finding became a rule for the app:

What we learned	So the app must…
Long setups wear people out	Set up in 5 minutes and save your place
Out of sight is out of mind	Show safe-to-spend first, and count down to bills
Missed days and red numbers cause shame	Offer a fresh start and kind words, with no streaks
Reward-and-punish tools backfire (Spiel et al., 2022)	Let people set their own goals and help design the app
Adults with ADHD symptoms save less (Bangma et al., 2020)	Give savings its own bucket

3. Product research and planning documents

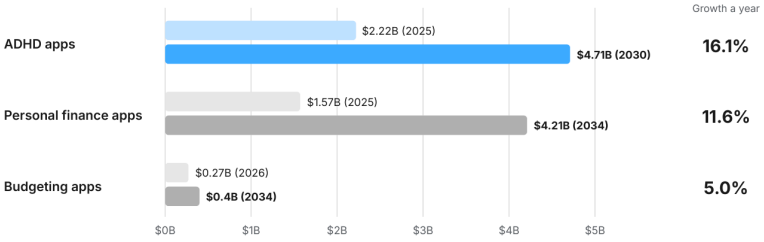
I made each of these as a one-page, easy-to-read PDF:

Document	What it shows
Market Landscape	The market for ADHD apps is growing, from about $2.22 billion in 2025 to $4.71 billion by 2030
Competitive Analysis	How YNAB, Monarch, Rocket Money, PocketGuard and Tiimo compare; none pairs money tools with ADHD-first design
Feature Analysis	Which features matter most, and which competitors have them
Positioning	Who the app is for and why they would choose it
User Personas	Maya, the overwhelmed restarter, and Jordan, the surprise-hit spender
Release Vision and Scope	What the first version includes, what comes later, and how we measure success (2 pages)
Build Plan	How we build it, step by step

Document	What it shows
Technical Requirements	What the app must do and the safety rules it must follow

ADHD apps are the fastest-growing of our three markets

Market size in $ billions: today (light bar) and forecast (dark bar). Growth a year on the right.



Takeaway

Budgeting apps alone are a small market. Our edge is serving the fast-growing ADHD audience inside the larger personal finance market.

Forecasts end in different years (2030 or 2034), so compare growth rates, not end sizes. Published estimates vary between research firms because each defines its market differently, and no source projects as far as 2040.

Sources: Verified Market Reports, Budget Apps Market; The Business Research Company, ADHD Apps Global Market Report; Dataintelo, Personal Finance Apps Market. Company links: official websites.

From the Market Landscape PDF: ADHD apps are the fastest-growing of our three markets.

No current app pairs money tools with ADHD-first design

Feature	YNAB	Monarch	Rocket Money	PocketGuard	Tiimo	Our app
Safe-to-spend number	Partial	–	–	Yes	–	Yes
Automatic bill detection	Partial	Yes	Yes	Yes	–	Yes
Reset after a lapse	Partial	–	–	–	–	Yes
Pause before purchase	–	–	–	–	–	Yes
ADHD-first design	Partial	–	–	–	Yes	Yes

Partial: YNAB targets ADHD users but needs regular upkeep. A dash means the feature is not shown on the company's website.

Takeaway

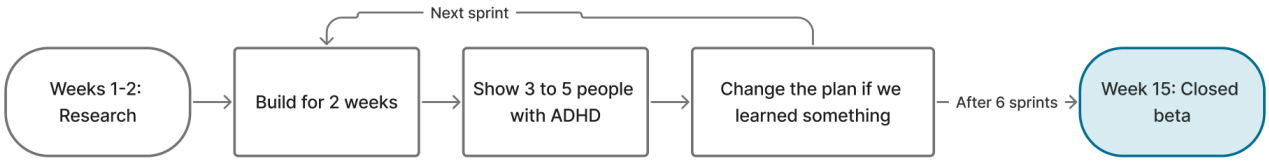
Money apps have the tools but not ADHD-first design. ADHD apps have the design but no money tools. Our edge is both, plus a guilt-free fresh start and a pause before buying, which no competitor offers.

Sources: each company's own website, October 2026; YNAB, Budgeting with ADHD; Avery Burk, "The Budget App That Might Save Your Bank Account," *Neurospicy Nom Noms*, December 2025. Customer claims and ratings come from the companies themselves, not independent reviews. Full 11-column analysis on the project FigJam board.

From the Competitive Analysis PDF: no current app pairs money tools with ADHD-first design.

4. An Agile build plan

- We build in **2-week sprints**. After each sprint we show the new work to 3 to 5 people with ADHD and change the plan if we learn something.
- Features are sorted into **Must, Should, Could and Won't (for now)**. The Musts come first: safe-to-spend, quick add, bill countdown, fresh start and quick setup.
- Timeline: research in weeks 1–2, six sprints in weeks 3–14, and a closed beta with about 100 testers with ADHD starting in week 15.
- If we run late, we drop features in this order: pause before buying, home-screen widget, bill finder, bank linking. **Safety is never dropped.**



How the sprints work: build, show people with ADHD, adjust, and repeat.

5. Keeping money safe

I checked the plan against banking security rules and wrote them into the technical requirements (17 feature, 14 security and 14 design rules in total):

- Money data is encrypted on the phone and opens only with face, fingerprint or passcode.
- The app locks itself after 5 idle minutes.
- Balances are blurred when you switch apps, and stay hidden when the phone wakes.
- A triple tap saves only once, and a failed save undoes itself.

6. Product backlog with acceptance criteria

I built a Kanban board in Notion with **22 user stories**, one for each feature across all 4 epics plus the security foundation. Each card has:

- the user story;
- **acceptance criteria** written as "Given … when … then …", for example: *Given I tap Save three times fast, when it saves, then only one expense is saved*;
- a definition of done (works on a real phone, tests pass, kind wording, accessibility and security checks pass);
- tags for its epic, priority, sprint and persona.

The board has three views: Kanban (Backlog → Ready → In progress → In review → Done), By epic and By priority.

Feature Analysis: Epics and Features

Epics 1 to 3 ship in MVP #1 (closed beta). Epic 4 ships in the MMP (public launch). Tags show the main audience: **A1** overwhelmed restarter · **A2** surprise-hit spender · **A3** couples where one partner has ADHD.

Epic 1: Easy Start MVP #1

Get users from download to a useful money view in about 3 minutes, before motivation fades.

Feature	So that…	Example
Goal picker	the app sets itself up around what I care about	"Stop surprise bills" puts the bill countdown first
Optional bank linking	a trust decision does not block me	Skip linking, type a balance, link later
Automatic bill detection A2	I don't have to remember and enter bills	Confirm each likely bill with one tap
Smart default categories A1	I skip building a budget from scratch	Start with 5 simple categories
Step progress and autosave	I can come back without starting over	Reopen mid-setup at the same step

Epic 2: Money at a Glance MVP #1

Keep the one number that matters always in view, and make logging take seconds.

Feature	So that…	Example
Safe-to-spend number	I don't do the math in my head	The number is the first thing on open
Home-screen widget	I see my money without opening the app	Glance before buying lunch
Automatic transaction import	the app stays accurate when I forget it	Fix a category once and it is remembered
Quick add	logging actually happens, in two taps	Log $12 coffee from the widget
Bill countdown A2	nothing catches me off guard	"Phone bill: 3 days left" on home screen

Epic 3: Calm, Guilt-Free Habits MVP #1

Help users keep going, and come back easily when they don't.

Feature	So that…	Example
Fresh start A1	catching up never stops me from coming back	"Welcome back. Want a fresh start?"
Gentle weekly check-in	I stay on track without daily effort	Sunday 7 pm, 60 seconds; no streaks
Snoozable reminders	reminders help instead of annoy	Remind 2 days before each bill; snooze
Pause before purchase A2	I can stop an impulse buy in time	"Still want it? Check again in 24 hours"
Focus Mode	I finish what I opened the app to do	Show only safe-to-spend and quick add

Epic 4: Shared Support and Progress MMP

Extend the app to partners and coaches, and make progress visible over months.

Feature	So that…	Example
Couples mode A3	tracking doesn't fall on one person	Each partner picks what to share
Coach sharing	my coach helps without me making reports	Coach sees check-ins, not transactions
Savings goals with visual progress A1	progress feels real	A "trip" goal with a filling progress bar
Body-doubling check-ins	money tasks get done with company	15-minute group bill review, camera off
New recurring charge alerts A2	subscriptions don't sneak in	"Is this a new subscription?"

Each "so that" is the benefit from the feature's user story ("As a [user], I want [feature], so that [benefit]"). Full user stories and three use-case scenarios per feature are on the project FigJam board.

Sources: ADHD Budgeting App PRD; Epics and Features (Tech Fleet template).

The four epics and their features, from the Feature Analysis PDF. These became the user stories on the board.

7. Pitch deck

I updated our 5-minute pitch deck to 11 slides using our three brand colors (cream, teal and deep blue) with plenty of white space. I added slides for the user personas, technical requirements and build plan.

What's next

- Confirm the beta start date, who the beta is for, and the app's name.
- Start Sprint 1: the security foundation.
- Recruit beta testers with ADHD, aiming for 150 sign-ups and about half women.

Sources

- Spiel, K., Hornecker, E., Williams, R. M., & Good, J. (2022). *ADHD and technology research: Investigated by neurodivergent readers.* CHI 2022.
- Bangma, D. F., Tucha, L., Fuermaier, A. B. M., Tucha, O., & Koerts, J. (2020). *Financial decision-making in a community sample of adults with and without current symptoms of ADHD.* PLOS ONE, 15(10), e0239343.
- Five ADHD UX design guides (2025 to 2026): Accessibility Checker, UXPA, Din Studio, Design Monks and iFactory.
- The Business Research Company, *ADHD Apps Global Market Report*.
- Scalevista, *Agile MVP Development Guide*.
- Our own project documents: PRD, MVP Build Plan, Technical Requirements and the FigJam research board.